Chemicals had ‘reorganised into three SBUs [Strategic Business Units] chemicals, fertilisers and food additives’. He added that with the company ‘looking for various projects and means of investing’, it had ‘earmarked Rs 70 crore as capital expenditure’ for the following year.

Ratan frequently pushed for his group companies to be innovative to increase their competitiveness. With this focus, he prodded Tata Chemicals to start an innovation centre, which took shape in 2004 in Pune as the Tata Chemicals Innovation Centre. It developed highly innovative products or processes relating to agriculture, soda ash and wellness products and won twenty-two patents. His thrust towards modernization and development saw the Babrala township, the nerve centre of the group’s ‘crop nutrition business’, being awarded an ISO 14001 certification.

In about a decade after taking over as chairman, Ratan was able to increase the turnover of Tata Chemicals by nearly four times. The company became the leader in soda ash and branded iodized salt in the domestic market.

Looking Overseas

Growing inorganically through the acquisitions, especially of foreign companies, was a strategy that Ratan had prescribed for all Tata companies as early as in his 1983 Strategic Plan. He implemented this vigorously in Tata Chemicals.

Mukundan recalls that Ratan was emphatic that the company should look outside India to become more competitive and achieve higher growth. He made his intention clear to Menon and in 2001 the company began a hunt for valuable foreign assets. This emphasis and the success he achieved while pursuing this goal is what Menon considers to be Ratan’s ‘singular achievement’.

Menon explained to a newspaper that ‘as part of enhancing growth in the new markets, the company would form strategic alliances and partnerships in addition to restructuring of the marketing, logistics and distribution set-up’. With Tata Chemicals boasting a market share of 37 per cent for its salt business, the company was looking for exports to Sri Lanka and the Middle East. It was only the beginning.

In 2005, Tata Chemicals acquired a one-third stake in Indo Maroc Phosphore SA (IMACID), a Moroccan JV ‘engaged in the manufacture of